

HOW INDIGO GETS MORE BANG FOR THE BUCK

INDIGO HAS LESS PILOTS THAN AIR INDIA

- Six departures per aircraft per day as against average of four by others
- IndiGo ensures 14 hours daily flying per aircraft as against 8.5 by others

IndiGo	AIR INDIA	Akasa Air	SpiceJet
PILOTS			
5,085	6,350	466	385
OPERATIONAL AIRCRAFT			
430	187	31	36
AIRCRAFT ON ORDER			
948	570	196	*
MARKET SHARE(%)			
65	27.3	5	2

NOTE * LEASING AIRCRAFT (20 FOR WINTER SCHEDULE)

SOURCE MOCA/DGCA

PILOT-TO-AIRCRAFT RATIO FOR INDIGO

- IndiGo is inducting more aircraft but pilot ratio on a decline
- The airline needs 900 more pilots by 2026-end

	PILOT STRENGTH	FLEET SIZE	PILOTS PER AIRCRAFT
FY25	5,456	434	12.6
FY24	5,038	367	13.7
FY23	4,407	304	14.5
FY22	3,791	275	13.8
FY21	3,734	285	13.1

SOURCE INDIGO ANNUAL REPORT

FINANCIAL PERFORMANCE OF KEY AIRLINES

- IndiGo was the only national carrier to report profit in FY25
- The airline has posted losses in the first two quarters of FY26

CARRIER	FY23 (IN ₹CRORE)	FY24 (IN ₹CRORE)	FY25 (IN ₹CRORE)
IndiGo	-317	8,167	7,253
Air India	-11,388	-4,444	-3,976
Vistara	-1,397	-589	NA
Air India Express	116	-163	-583
Air Asia	-2,748	-1,149	NA
Akasa	-2,748	-1,670	-1,986
SpiceJet	-1,513	-404	-56

NOTE PROFIT OR LOSS (AFTER INCOME TAXES & EXTRAORDINARY ITEMS); AIR ASIA AND VISTARA MERGED WITH AIR INDIA **SOURCE** DGCA, BT RESEARCH

has been saying that there is more to the IndiGo crisis than just the pilot shortage, especially now that the airline is also denying a pilot crunch. “We have said from day one that there is no pilot shortage; it’s an intentional thing done by IndiGo. They have a shortage of 200 pilots, but why did they cancel around 1,600 flights on December 5? It should be investigated in depth,” says Randhawa.

Lazar says there is also a need to ensure that airlines have adequate manpower before adding new routes/fleet. As the airline is expected to add one new aircraft per week, it will need 11,000 pilots in the next 10 years to keep up with its growth aspirations, according to the government data.

According to projections, India needs to produce 2,000 pilots a year to keep up with the order book of the carriers, but DGCA issued 1,342 commercial pilot licences in 2024 and 1,622 in 2023. The flying schools are also grappling with a shortage of certified instructors.

REGULATOR RESET

The crisis has brought into focus the role of the DGCA and regulatory challenges that have prevented the emergence of strong airlines in the country. Airline operators flag high fuel charges and airport taxes as reasons behind the duopoly in the aviation market.

“The aviation sector has not grown the way it should have because of the policies of the government. They need to de-monopolise the sector and for that they must change the policies,” says Randhawa. He says privatisation of airports, primarily with one private operator, has led to multiplication of airport charges, which account for 30-40% additional cost for an airline and are passed on to consumers. The new Navi Mumbai International Airport has